



serving Mauritius left him unable to practise properly for about a month. "But when you have a goal, when you have passion, it doesn't matter. You just do it. I don't get tired when I log in and practise with my team. The tiredness just goes away," he says.

For Israr Ahmed, the youngest member of the team, the problem has sometimes been explaining that there is even a sport to prepare for. Applying to his university for permission to miss classes for the Asian Games, he had to explain what esports was and why it counted. "They wanted to know if I even counted as an athlete, and I had to tell them yes; I do count as an athlete. It's a medal event," he says.

Officially launched in 2009, League of Legends has an estimated 8 million players playing simultaneously at its peak. India's player base is only a fraction of that. Akshaj estimates the official Indian League community has around 4,000 to 5,000 members, with perhaps 1,000 active players. "We have probably one thousandth or one ten thousandth of the player base that South Korea has," he says. India also has no dedicated League server, so the team plays on Singapore's at a relatively high latency of 80-90 milliseconds, which falls to almost zero at the Asian Games on a local server, creating its own problem.

"Playing at high ping is like playing with a weighted vest. The player becomes accustomed to the extra resistance, unconsciously compensating for the delay. At a tournament, the vest comes off, and suddenly everything is faster," Mihir says.

The depth of competition differs too: India's players can dominate the ecosystem available to them without being tested against the best in the world. Hangzhou provided a painful demonstration of what that means. India came through the group stage but ran into Vietnam in the quarterfinals, losing both matches in under 20 minutes each, well short of the usual 30 to 35. "Vietnam destroyed us," Mihir admits. The Vietnamese players had been professionals for years, salaried, with World Championships experience and established careers to study. "They were doing things that we didn't know were possible," says Mihir.

Ahead of the 2026 Games, the team has tried to narrow that gap. Israr and Rahul were brought in this year to strengthen the squad, which now competes under the banner of S8UL, an Indian esports and content platform. They've set up scrims with top teams from South and West Asia and analyse the results much as other sports teams conduct post-match video reviews, while tracking constant changes to the game's patches and meta.

They also reject the idea that a sport played sitting down doesn't place demands on the body. Aakash is a regular at the gym; Akshaj lifts and plays badminton; others make an effort to exercise between sessions. "They spend hours sitting. Their backs hurt. Their wrists take punishment. Their concentration has to remain high for extended periods," says Aakash. "The more physically fit we are, the better we play."

Living and training together, as

A dream come true: India's esports contingent (from left): Israr, Sanindhya, Rahul, Aakash, Akshaj, Mihir. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

elite teams do, remains unrealistic. "If we sit together and train for six months without doing anything else, we probably would be better, but right now even if you put us in the same city it wouldn't work out," says Sanindhya. "We all have our own lives to live, and we would probably still be playing out of our homes."

But there are moments when it comes together. In qualifying for these Asian Games, India fell thousands of gold behind against Jordan before recovering to win. "That was a really hype moment," says Aakash.

In Hangzhou, Aakash met two-time Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra and other Indian athletes, but the meeting he was most excited about was with Lee Sang-hyeok, the legendary Korean player known as 'Faker'. "He was always the guy I grew up watching on streams or in World Championships. It's like if you got to meet Sachin [Tendulkar] or [Lionel] Messi," Aakash says.

Folded away in Mihir's cupboard is a reminder of what the late nights are for: a couple of blue T-shirts with India written on them, his kit from Hangzhou. "It's basically passion that's driving all of us. It's not like we make a living out of this... I don't go and tell people about the fact that I've played for India at the Asian Games. But I don't think there's anything as special as getting the opportunity to wear the India jersey. I gave one set to my grandparents, and it was one of the most sentimental moments of my life. It didn't matter what kind of sports person I was. It was the India jersey. And when you wear it, everything we do seems to be worth it," he says.

TOTAL MEDALS AT STAKE

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